Johannes de Muris — Libellus cantus mensurabilis (c. 1340)

The Boneyard is a collection of works left unfinished, unpublished, or unread at their authors' deaths — dry bones in the valley, in Ezekiel's image. Each presentation tells the scholar's story, weighs what survives of his work, and states plainly what completing it would take, so that a book the world never received whole can be met at last. Each of them was one of one. There will never be another like him, and his light will not shine again except through the work he left behind.

A Boneyard dossier — researched and presented by Robert Tilford, Hays, Kansas. Filed 17 October 2026.

Disclosure: prepared with AI assistance — the six subject reviewers named in the index are AI agents, each desk-checked at this desk; all rulings and final decisions are the author's own.

Dedication

To Johannes de Muris, a native of the diocese of Lisieux in Normandy, whose name the manuscripts attach to a small book that taught measured song for centuries. The life record that survives for him is thin, and this dedication does not pretend otherwise. What is not thin is the work's classroom life. Cited also as the *Ars practica mensurabilis cantus*, it survives in more than fifty manuscripts. A scholar who finished a calendar in 1321 while staying at the poor students' hostel of the Sorbonne left a lesson that classrooms kept copying long after him.

The author's own terms

Sincopa — syncopation, in the treatise's own definition: the division of any figure through separated parts which, by counting the perfections, are reduced to one another; and it can happen in modus, tempus, and prolatio.

The story

Johannes de Muris, also given as Jean des Murs, was a French mathematician, astronomer, and music theorist. By 1318 he was living in Évreux while taking

part in scholastic work in Paris, and his writings place him as a resident of the Collège de Sorbonne until around 1325. In March 1326 he settled at Fontevraud Abbey and remained associated with it until 1332 or 1333, when he returned to Évreux. Records in his own hand place him again in Paris in 1336, and in 1342 he was one of six canons at Mézières-en-Brenne. In 1344 Pope Clement VI invited him to Avignon for the calendar reform, and 1345 is the last date associated with him. The circumstances of his death are not given in the record, and they are not supplied here.

The work and what survives

The *Libellus*, dated to about 1340, stands fourth among five music treatises associated with him. Its opening is careful about authorship: what follows is presented as summarily compiled according to Master John of Muris, and that is the form this presentation keeps. In ten treatises it sets out the five parts of prolation, imperfection, alteration, the dot, the signs of time, the six rhythmic modes, ligatures, syncopation, rests, the diminution of motets, and color. The Latin text's printed home is Coussemaker's edition of 1864, volume 3, pages 46 to 58. Under the fuller title *Ars practica mensurabilis cantus secundum Iohannem de Muris*, Christian Berktold published a critical edition in 1999 presenting the *Recensio maior*. One scholarly count gives more than fifty surviving manuscripts, and a second gives at least fifty-three. A version forms the mensuration section of the Berkeley Treatise, dated 1375, and a fifteenth-century Italian translation survives as well.

Its English fortunes

The project folder holds a complete draft translation of all ten treatises, made from Coussemaker's Latin. Beyond that desk, the finding stands at a bounded strength. **No complete English translation found after research.** Two bounds belong with that sentence. Scholars quote single definitions from the *Libellus* in English in secondary literature, among them *sincopa* and the distinction of *color* and *talea*, without translating the treatise whole. And a complete modern translation does exist in French, in Christian Meyer's *Jean de Murs, Écrits sur la musique* (CNRS, 2000). The 1994 English edition by C. Matthew Balensuela translates the anonymous borrowing work *Ars cantus mensurabilis mensurata per modos iuris*, not the *Libellus* itself.

What completing it would take

The folder's draft already exists whole, and it states plainly that the final checks required before public use have not yet been done. Completing it would mean specialist review by a reader of medieval music and mensural notation, then collation beyond Coussemaker against Berktold's 1999 *Recensio maior*, with the recension followed stated and the manuscript variants the folder lists sampled. It would also mean settling the notated examples, which the folder renders in words only and does not draw: either redraw them faithfully, or keep the words-only rule as a stated bound. Two marks of transmission should stay visible: the sixth treatise's printed *sine perfectione*, likely for *sine proprietate*, and the tenth treatise's chapter headed *Capitulum decimum* where first is meant.

Sources

- Project folder: ~/workspace/rare-and-obscure-books/books/johannes-de-muris-libellus/johannes-de-muris-libellus.txt (Coussemaker, vol. 3, pp. 46–58)
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Johannes_de_Muris (life and works)
- https://ora.ox.ac.uk/objects/uuid:93b2d35e-d5ef-46d1-816e-eac25da1aa9e/files/m5c3ed7f78a72ed561bf95a7138fc1f13 (Sorbonne colophons)
- https://mural.maynoothuniversity.ie/id/eprint/19864/1/1)_Introduction_ed.pdf (Lisieux origin)
- https://www.thefreelibrary.com/The+manuscript+sources+of+Divina+auxiliante+gratia-a0281374837 (alternate title; manuscripts)
- https://www.academia.edu/118677276/Jean_des_Murs_s_Quadrivial_Pursuits_Introduction (at least 53 manuscripts)
- https://troja.publia.org/troja/article/download/3953/3791 (Berktold, 1999)
- https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_Berkeley_Treatise (Berkeley reuse, 1375)
- https://www.academia.edu/48973960/Playing_with_the_performer

(sincopa; Meyer, 2000)

- http://carrels.distantreader.org/journal-currentMusicology-ojsoai/cache/currentmusicology-3690.pdf (color and talea)
- https://www.academia.edu/5676257/In_Pursuit_of_Origins_Text_Underlay (Italian translation)